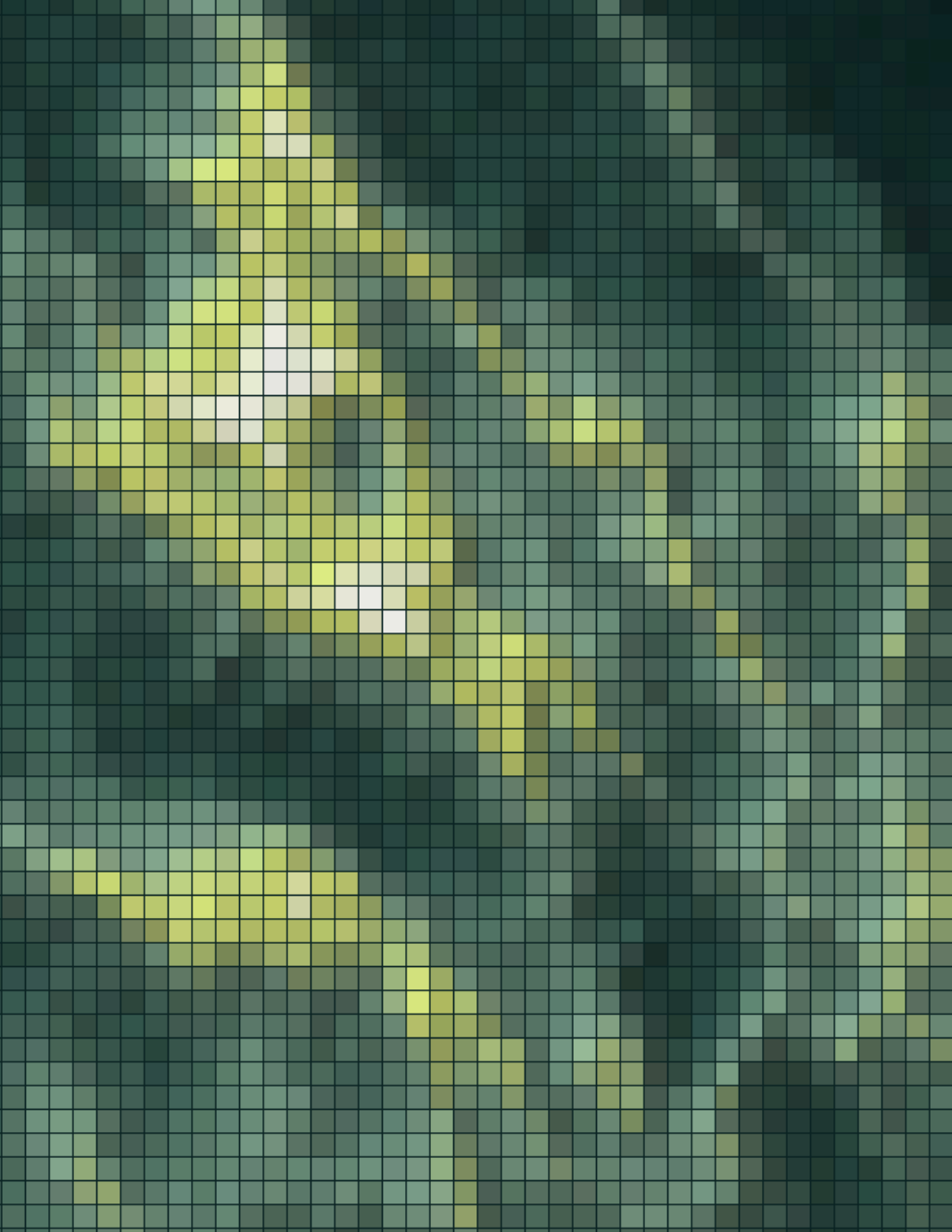


HCO

High Country Observations



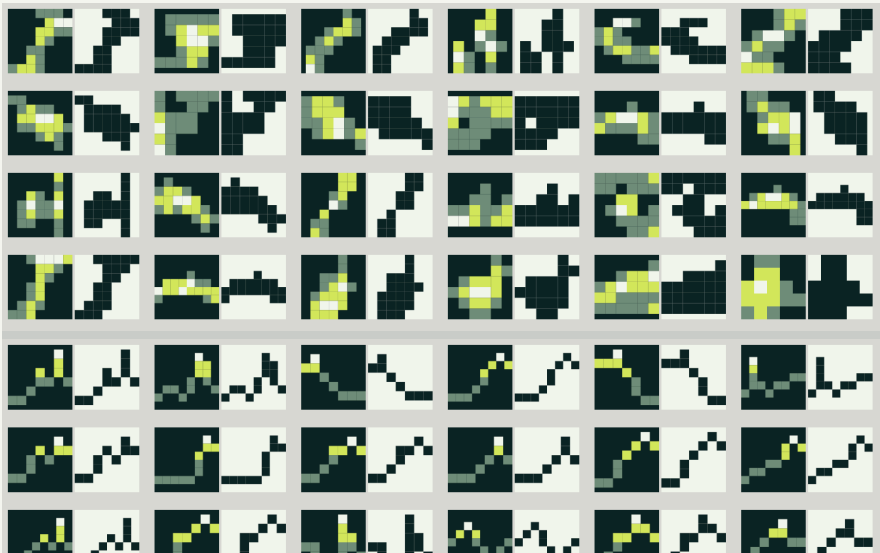
PROCESS

Found in the terrain. Drawn by hand.



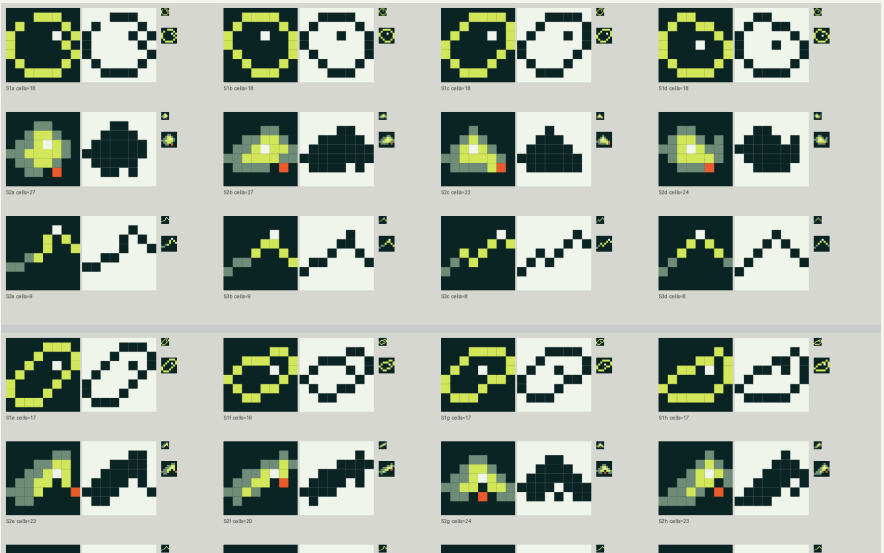
1 · One dataset

Band-limited fractal terrain with ridged, anisotropic ranges. Illustrative and procedural: it is not real elevation data and implies no location.



2 · 2,379 samples

Sampled from above (heightmaps, contours) and from the side (profiles), then filtered against the brief: $\leq 8 \times 8$ cells, one form, asymmetric, a small summit.



3 · 25 drawn, 3 survive

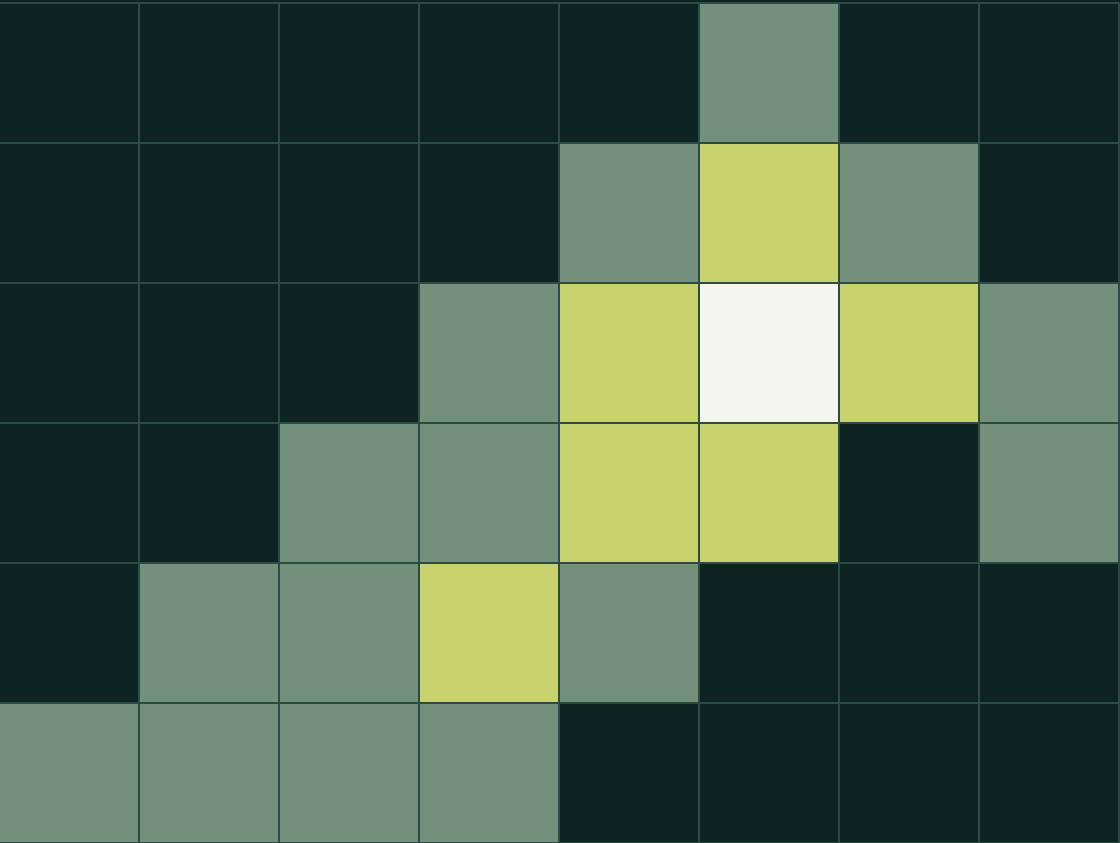
Redrawn by hand on the grid in clean runs. Contour rings read as eyes; most heightmaps read as blobs. Three studies go forward.

WHAT THE TEST CHANGED

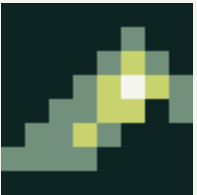
The brief expected the view from above to win. It didn't. A side view survives the ziggurat and bar-chart traps once it plots the surface — one measured line — instead of filling the mass. That is study S3, Ridgeline.

STUDY 1 · PLAN RASTER

Massif



8 × 6 grid · 22 cells · one module



16 px × 6



Actual 16 · 24 · 32 px, pixel-aligned

The summit seen from above, as a drone survey would map it: a small heightmap of cells, coloured from Sage on the lower slopes to Lichen on the ridge and Chalk at the summit.

STRENGTHS

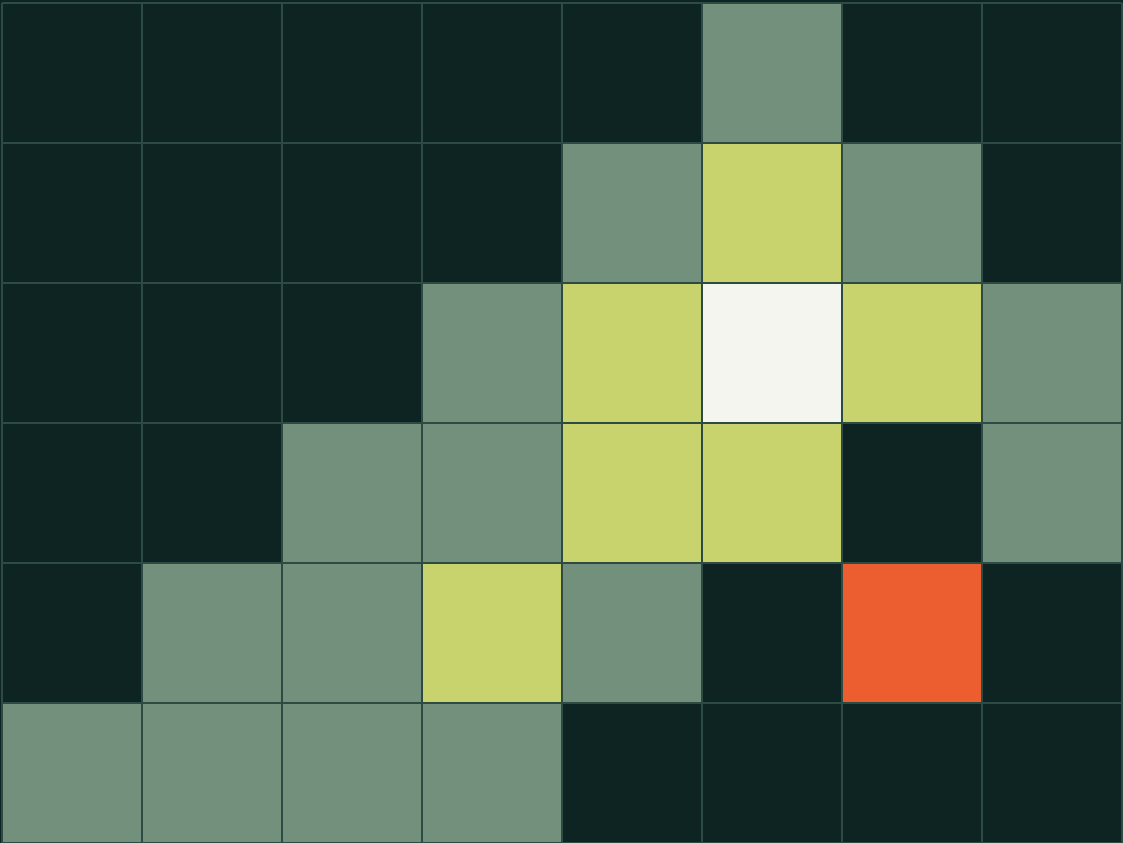
- The richest use of the palette: the logo is literally a data tile.
- Holds at 16 px on a Basalt tile.

WEAKNESSES

- In one colour it falls back into a pixel peak — the stock “pixel mountain” form already sold as off-the-shelf outdoor logos.
- Without colour, the idea disappears.

STUDY 2 · PLAN RASTER WITH FLAG

Observation



8 × 6 grid · 23 cells · one module



16 px × 6



Actual 16 · 24 · 32 px, pixel-aligned

Massif with one cell flagged in survey orange: the terrain measured, and the one place that needs attention marked. It is the business in one cell — identify the issue.

STRENGTHS

- The strongest story of the three: data, then judgement.
- The Flag cell can carry through maps, reports and the website.

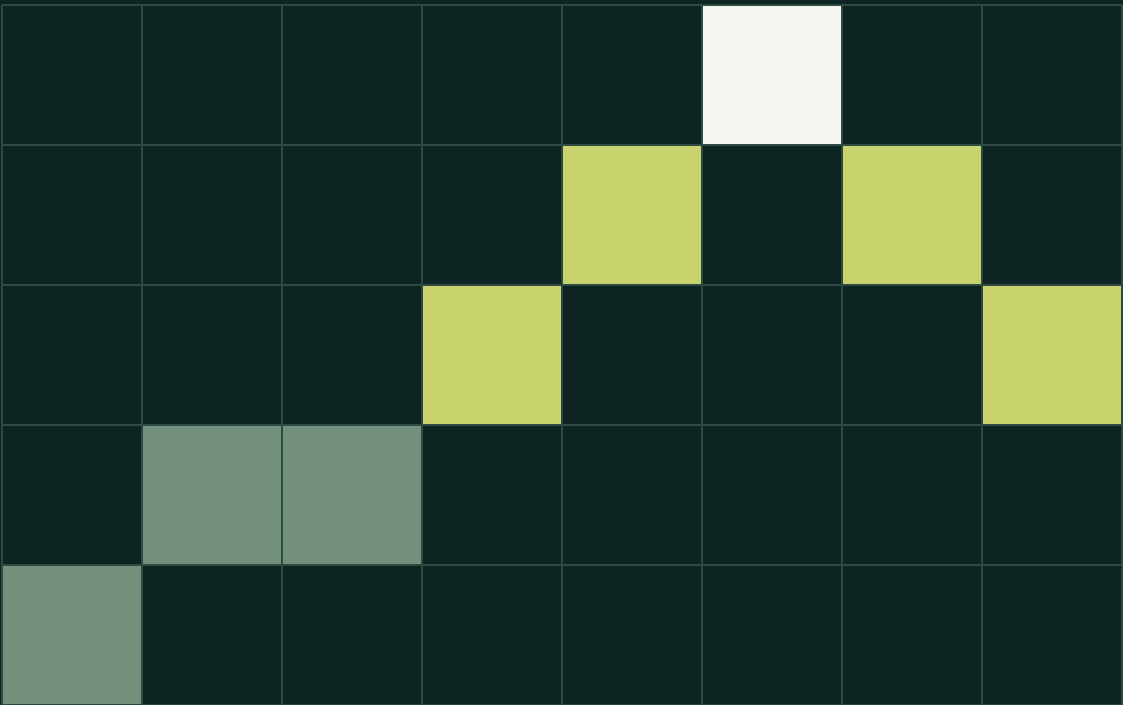
WEAKNESSES

- Shares Massif's one-colour weakness.
- At 16 px the Flag is a 2 × 2 px dot — legible, but fragile.

STUDY 3 · PROFILE, PLOTTED AS A MEASURED LINE

Ridgeline

RECOMMENDED



8 × 5 grid · 8 cells · one module



16 px × 6



Actual 16 · 24 · 32 px, pixel-aligned

The ridge in section, plotted the way an elevation profile is: one measured cell per step, coloured by height. A long approach, the summit in Chalk, a short steep drop. Drawn with the same weight as the letters — one cell is one stem.

STRENGTHS

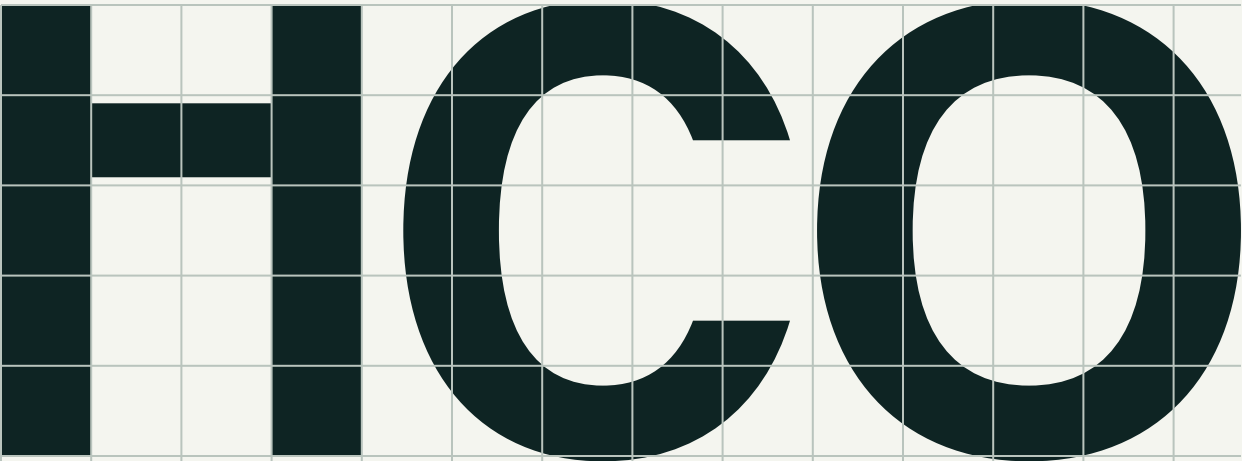
- Reads at once as a mountain and as measured data — and not as a pyramid or a bar chart.
- Pixel-perfect at 16 px; the line and the letters share one stroke.
- Not found among existing pixel-mountain marks (search recorded, not clearance).

WEAKNESSES

- In one colour it is close to a rising-line chart; the drop after the summit and the context have to do the work.
- Light next to the bold HCO at very small sizes — use the compact lockup below 120 px.

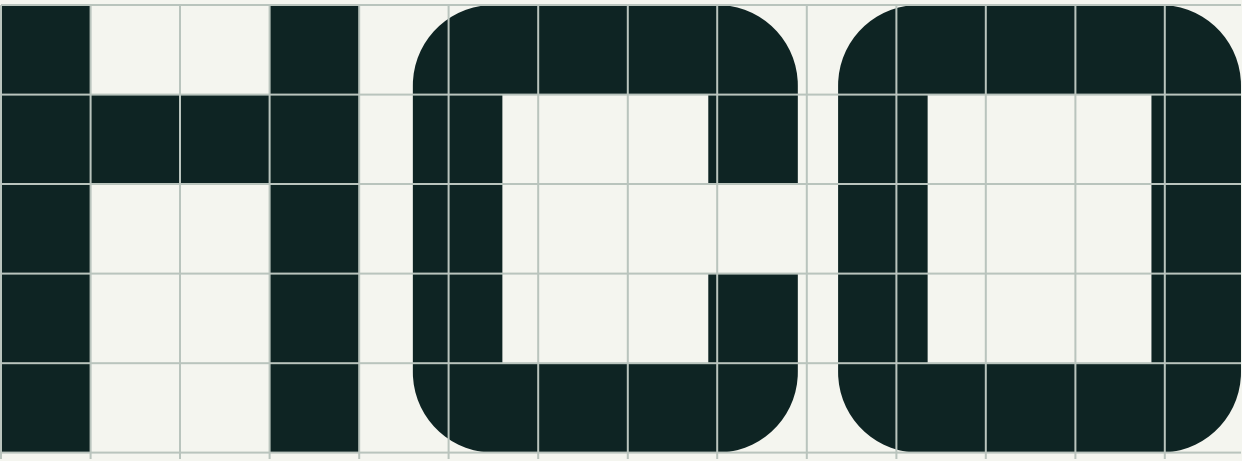
WORDMARK

Drawn on the same module as the symbol



W1 · High Bar RECOMMENDED

Drawn letters on the module: stem = one cell, cap height = five cells, the raised crossbar sitting in row four (centre at 70%). Round, readable, and clearly custom next to a pixel symbol.



W2 · Grid-built

Squared letters built from the module. Consistent with the symbol, but it reads as a display or game face and pulls the brand towards tech — exactly the drift the brief warns against.

RECOMMENDED · RIDGELINE WITH HIGH BAR



Primary · with descriptor



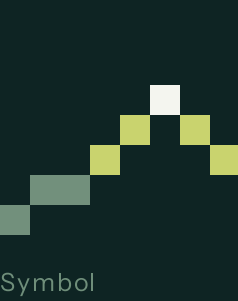
Compact



Stacked



Wordmark



Symbol



Primary · with descriptor



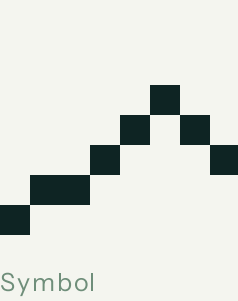
Compact



Stacked



Wordmark



Symbol

Full colour only on Basalt. On Chalk and other light grounds, the one-colour Basalt version — Lichen on Chalk measures 1.47:1.

CONSTRUCTION

One measure for everything



01 1 module = one cell = one stem

02 Cap height = 5 modules

03 Crossbar in row 4 of 5 (centre 70%)

04 Symbol 8 × 5 cells, standing on the baseline

05 Gap = 1 module; H = 4 modules wide

06 Descriptor: the width of HCO, baseline 1.5 modules down

07 Clear space = 2 modules on every side

MINIMUM · PRIMARY

240 px wide on screen · 40 mm in print

MINIMUM · COMPACT

96 px wide · 18 mm

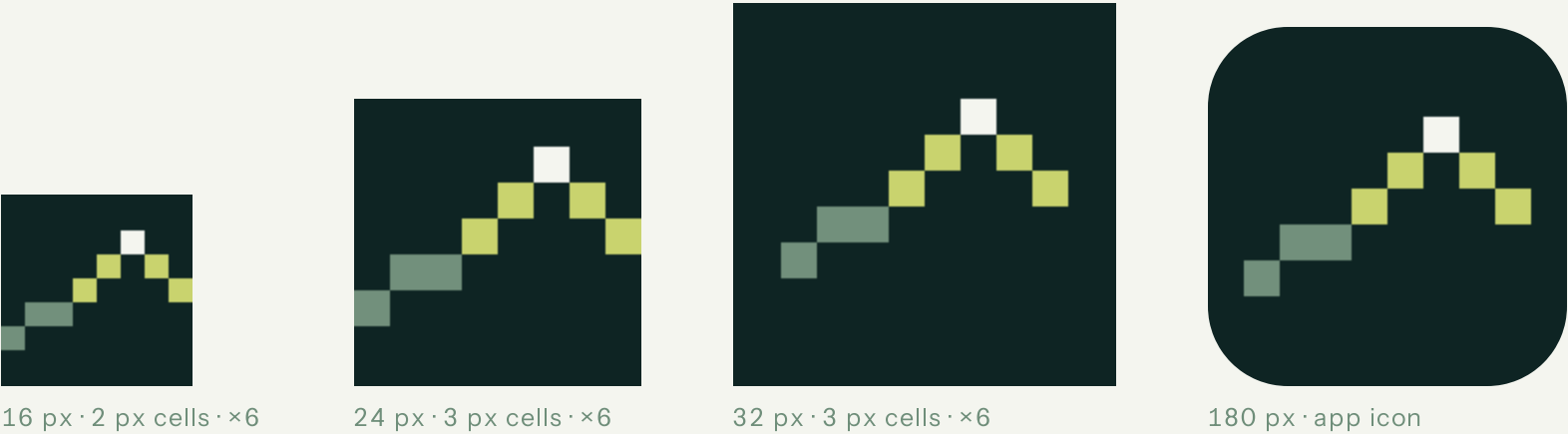
MINIMUM · SYMBOL

16 px (2 px per cell) · 5 mm

Provisional: print minimums to be proofed

SMALL SIZES

Built for the pixel grid: every cell lands on whole pixels



AT ACTUAL SIZE



Website header study · compact lockup at 28 px · illustrative navigation

RULE

Below 120 px wide, drop the descriptor and use the compact lockup. Below 48 px, use the symbol alone. Favicons always sit on a Basalt tile, so the full-colour ramp stays legible.

COLOUR

The palette is the elevation ramp

Basalt

#0E2423 · RGB 14, 36, 35

Field · about 60%

Chalk

#F4F5EF · RGB 244, 245, 239

Type and light ground · about 25%

Lichen

#C9D36E · RGB 201, 211, 110

Signal: the highest value · about 10%

Flag

#EC5D2F · RGB 236, 93, 47

The observation · under 3%

RAMP · LOW → HIGH · SYMBOL, MAPS AND REPORTS

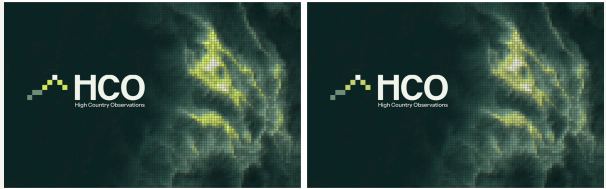
Basalt #0E2423

Moss #2E4B43

Sage #72907C

Lichen #C9D36E

Chalk #F4F5EF



Study 01 lime #D6E65D (left) vs Lichen #C9D36E

Lichen moves from Study 01's lime (#D6E65D) to a mineral #C9D36E. It is still unmistakably the signal colour, at 10.06:1 on Basalt, but it reads as lichen on rock rather than the tech “volt” green that has dated fast since 2024.

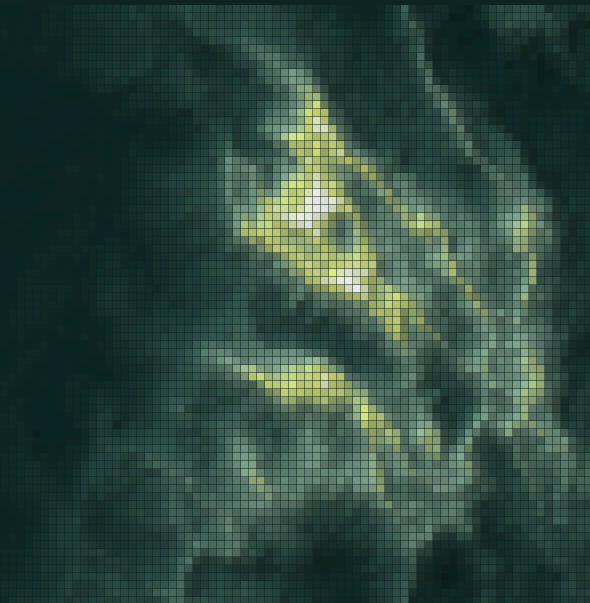
MEASURED CONTRAST (WCAG)

on	Chalk / Basalt	14.79:1	Text
on	Lichen / Basalt	10.06:1	Text
on	Flag / Basalt	4.77:1	Text
on	Sage / Basalt	4.63:1	Text
on	Basalt / Chalk	14.79:1	Text
on	Flag / Chalk	3.10:1	Large text, graphics
on	Lichen / Chalk	1.47:1	Never for text or marks

HEX and RGB only. No Pantone or CMYK until a print profile is agreed with a supplier.

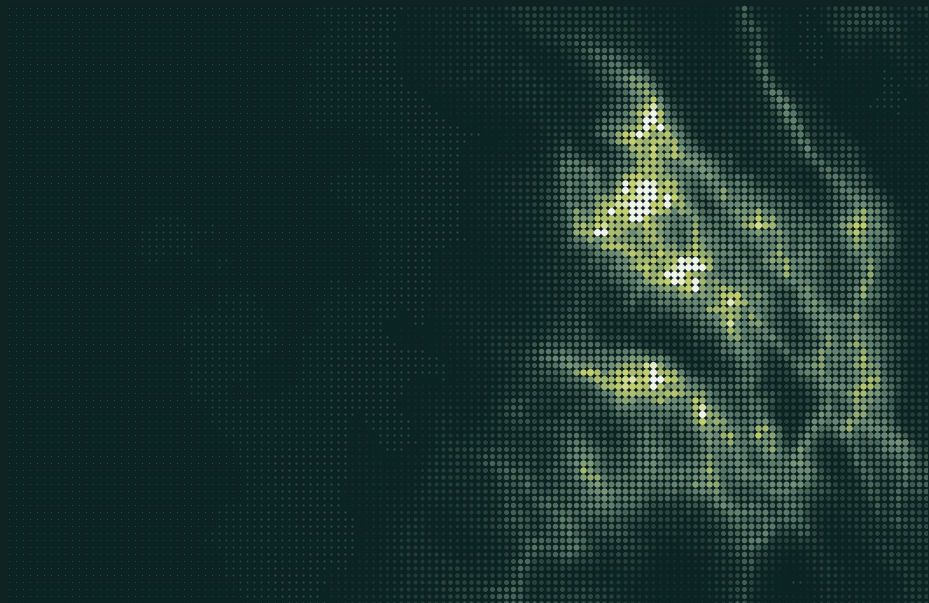
BACKGROUND

One dataset, three renderings



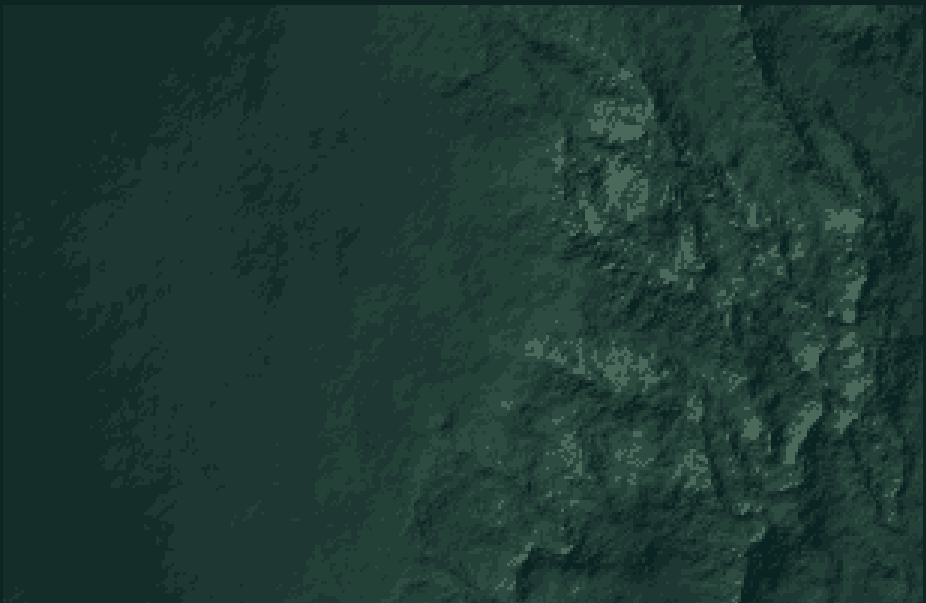
A · Pixel heightmap

Cells coloured by the ramp, lit by the relief. The symbol at full resolution — the hero mode.



B · Dot matrix

Dot size is elevation. A quieter, more editorial texture for reports and covers.



C · Quantised hillshade

Relief in six field tones, no signal colour. The quietest: safe under long text.

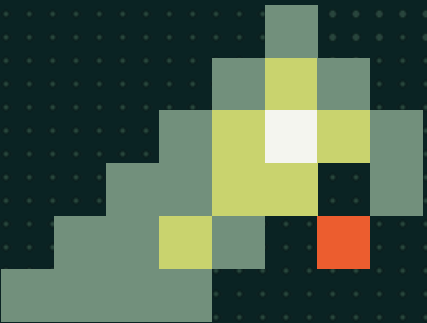
RULES

Logo sits in the quiet lowland, never over a ridge. Text over terrain measures $\geq 4.5:1$ against the busiest area beneath it. No glow, blur or cinematic lighting.

DATA

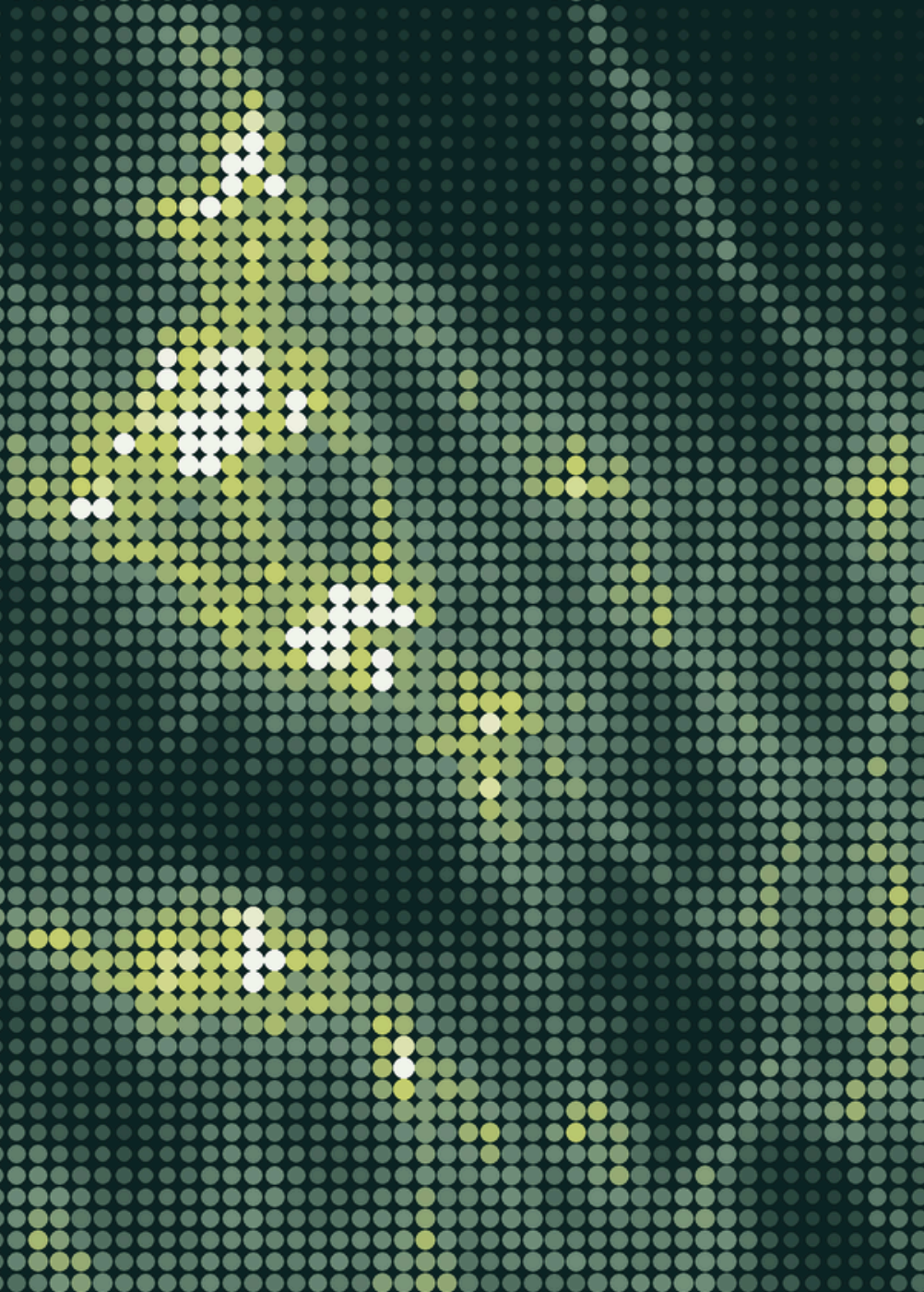
Procedural and labelled “Illustrative terrain study” until a real region is confirmed; then Copernicus GLO-30 (attributed) or USGS 3DEP. No place names or coordinates.

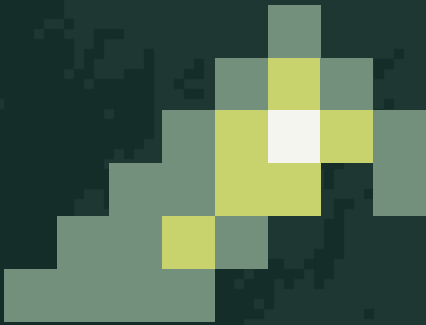




HCO

High Country Observations





HCO

High Country Observations

WITHOUT THE BACKGROUND

Each study, flat — the test the terrain can't help with



S3 · Ridgeline

Still a measured ridge in one colour. Survives.

S2 · Observation

Flag lost in one colour; reads as a pixel peak.

S1 · Massif

Reads as a pixel peak — the stock form.

EVALUATION

Judged against the brief

	S3 · RIDGELINE	S2 · OBSERVATION	S1 · MASSIF
Reads as terrain or data in five seconds			Heat-map tile
Holds at 16 px (module ≥ 2 px)	Pixel-perfect	Flag is 2 px	
Works in one colour, no background	Rising-line risk, held by the drop	Flag lost in mono	Pixel peak in mono
Advisory practice, not drone vendor or outdoor brand			Leans outdoor
Palette used as a data ramp			
Resemblance search (not clearance)	No close match found	Same family as stock pixel mountains	Close to stock pixel-mountain logos

meets the brief partly fails — designer judgement from the artwork and tests, not measured data



RECOMMENDATION

S3 Ridgeline with the High Bar wordmark, the mineral Lichen palette and the pixel-heightmap background as hero. Keep S2's Flag cell as a system device for maps and reports, not in the logo. On approval: refine, build the logo family and export the identity pack.